

Sexy PUBLICS

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By Perveez Mody

Those of us in the business of finding things out about the intimate lives of people have been told that something near a third of everything people say to a researcher will quite simply not be true. Social anthropologists like myself have long puzzled over this problem, because it is not just the issue of "reactivity" that troubles us—the problem of how people modulate their behaviour when asked questions by inquisitive social scientists—but also the much more complex issues surrounding the cultural context of questions, what is appropriate, what counts as a good question and finally, is the answer something that an informant is able to speak honestly about. Anthropologists overcome these issues by conducting extensive

of no surprise to me then that the only way in which a survey like this could work, the only way it could be acceptable for the respondents and for you, the reader, is because it is anonymous, and so plays with ideas of secrecy and publicity. Surveys such as this identify and create not secrets but "sexy publics". That is, they take the mundane, domestic and secret aspects of sexuality and propel them before our gaze in a very public forum such as a magazine with a national readership. We can see here the ways in which social groups project and reproduce images of themselves. There is a two-fold movement: the respondents project themselves through responding (with a greater or lesser degree of honesty at which we can only guess), and in reading about these "sexy secrets" the wider public projects itself back, comparing itself, imagining itself, imagining "the other"; and thus in some way creating itself.

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fieldwork within the contexts that they wish to study (be this the classic village ethnographies of yesteryear or the seemingly more exotic wide-boy culture of investment bankers in the city of London). My own research on love-marriages in Delhi in the late 1990s forced me to consider the not inconsequential issue that many of my informants living and working in the suburbs, shanties and heart of our national capital city chose to represent their marriages as "arranged" so as to evade the heavy moral freight that accompanied revelations of romantic self-choosing. In many cases their families came to collude in this dissimulation and I became very aware of the tensions between what people felt they could say publicly about what were difficult and thorny personal issues, and their need to conceal some aspects of their lives so as not to lose status or standing. It is

It is important to note that the interviewers who ran this survey selected respondents on the basis that they were resident in one of 11 of our major cities and fell within the high income/social class category (Sections 'A1, A2, B1 and B2'). The reason for this, I was told, was because this category of citizen-consumer is designated a "trend setter" which is an interesting phrase to pick when the trends discussed are sexual secrets. From my own work as well as that of the anthropologist Jonathan Parry who has worked recently amongst informal sector workers in Bhilai, I know that this image isn't the whole truth and other social categories may well have more "spicy" sex lives than is generally thought, so the survey may have skewed its results in unexpected ways by going sensationally for those it expected to be most sexually active. The survey both projects and fixes its gaze upon this group, the 18-40 year olds that we imagine populate the gymkhanas, bars, clubs, pubs, restaurants, corporations and call centres—the swinging India of it and infidelity, casual sexual encounters and of porn to accompany the popcorn. But too much